EXHIBITION

Time Travel

An exhibition in Bengaluru is showcasing an unseen artwork by legendary artist Raja Ravi Varma

There's no better way to celebrate the 'Father of Modern Indian Art', Raja Ravi Varma, than through a showcase that delves deep into the many layers of his life. On the occasion of Varma's 176th birth anniversary (which fell on April 29), the Raja Ravi Varma Heritage Foundation opened the exhibition *Daughter of Providence* within its premises on Bengaluru's Lavelle Road that will go on till May 30.

"The idea behind the showcase was to highlight various elements of Ravi



RAJA RAVI VARMA HERITAGE FOUNDATION

REGAL LEGACY Painting of a young Maharani Sethu Lakshmi Bayi (1898) by her grandfather Raja Ravi Varma; (below) her portrait by granddaughter Bharani Thirunal Rukmini Bayi Thampuran



BOOKS

A BREATH OF FRESH PERSPECTIVE

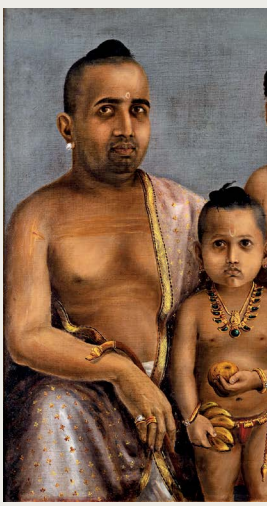
Ganesh V. Shivaswamy brings a sharp and balanced approach to his three volumes on Raja Ravi Varma

Hindsight is a great teacher. Even though there have been many volumes on the noble painter Raja Ravi Varma, the three under review show, with the present's technological telescopes zoomed on the past, that there is much room left for fresh interpretations. In 1894, an anonymous Malayalam book appeared on Ravi Varma which stopped at the opening of his Press in Bombay. Then came Ramananda Chatterjee in 1904, followed by Balakrishnan Nair in the 1950s, E.M.J. Venniyoor in 1980, and Rupika Chawla in 2010. What differentiates the tomes under review is not just the weight of the author's scholarship, but a very sharp eye which zooms into the many layers beyond the obvious.

The principal difference, which Shivaswamy brings with his work, is the awakening of the artist's context. He looks piercingly at the mindset of the period and the original, avant-garde vision of the protagonist.

In a fascinating lecture the author delivered at DAG, New Delhi, he pointed out that the first paid commission of Raja Ravi Varma was a 'legal', not 'regal', commission. It was Kizhakkepat Krishna Menon, Justice P. Muthuswamy Aiyar and G.P. Pillai who paid him to do portraits.

Looking at the precedents—the influences of murals, court paintings, photography—the eminent viewpoint of the author studies the whole process of image building. He also takes



COLLECTION DAG

A 'LEGAL' COMMISSION 'The Kizhakkepat Krishna Menon & Family' (1870) by Raja Ravi Varma